

Context Prune

Prompt

How can one prune irrelevant history from the Claude Code context

Response

Given your work with CLAUDE.md hierarchies, here's the current toolkit for pruning irrelevant history in Claude Code:

Core commands

- `/clear` — hard reset, wipes the conversation entirely, no summary. Best when switching to genuinely unrelated work (e.g., jumping from your Rust tutorial repo to a website CSS fix). CLAUDE.md files still reload automatically after this.
- `/compact` — replaces conversation history with a structured summary rather than deleting it. You can steer it: `/compact focus on the auth bug fix` keeps what you choose instead of what the automatic pass guesses matters. Best used proactively (before context gets crowded) rather than waiting for auto-compact, since Claude summarizes better with full recall and more headroom.
- `/context` — shows a live breakdown of what's actually consuming your context window (CLAUDE.md size, memory, MCP tool schemas, skills, conversation), with optimization suggestions. This is the first thing to run when a session feels sluggish, since sometimes it's not conversation history but bloated CLAUDE.md or too many MCP servers.

What survives `/compact` (relevant since you use path-scoped rules and nested CLAUDE.md):

- Project-root CLAUDE.md and unscoped rules: reloaded from disk
- Auto memory: reloaded from disk
- Rules with `paths: frontmatter: lost` until a matching file is read again — if you need one to persist, drop the `paths: frontmatter` or move it to root CLAUDE.md
- Nested CLAUDE.md in subdirectories (like your `Learn/` subfolder setup): **lost** until a file in that subdirectory is touched again
- Invoked skill bodies: reloaded but capped at 5,000 tokens/skill and 25,000 total, oldest dropped first — put critical instructions near the top of SKILL.md

Other levers

- **Subagents** keep large file reads out of your main context entirely — only the final summary comes back. Useful if you're doing broad exploration across your NewSite repo before deciding what to actually change.
- `/rewind` — undoes recent turns without accumulating corrective back-and-forth in history, better than piling on "no, actually do X instead" messages.

For your SDD workflow specifically, since you're already structuring `sdd_plan/sdd_implement` as discrete phases, `/compact` with a focused prompt between phases (or `/clear` between features) probably fits your existing `/clear` → load context → work pattern well.

Source: [Claude Code — Explore the context window](#)